

A Lightlike-Graph Audit of String Theory: Pseudo-Science, Productive Mathematics, or Something Else?

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July 12, 2026

Abstract

A vigorous public dispute surrounds string theory. Critics (most prominently Smolin and Woit) argue that, after four decades of effort, it has produced no experimental prediction sharp enough to falsify it and has therefore forfeited the status of a scientific theory. Defenders argue that the theory’s mathematical coherence, its many dualities, and its unification of gravity with the other interactions constitute progress that should not be judged by the standards of an earlier, more empirically forgiving, era. We do not take sides. Instead, we audit the dispute using the lightlike graph $\mathcal{G}$ introduced in the companion papers, in which the only primitive is the lightlike relation between emission and absorption events and the only questions are combinatorial: which edges exist, which vertices they share, how the degrees organise themselves. The audit is a diagnostic, not a verdict: it asks whether the apparatus of string theory produces new combinatorial possibilities on $\mathcal{G}$ (and would therefore generate new knowledge), exposes combinatorial redundancies already accessible (and would therefore be unnecessary complication), or misses combinatorial structure that the more austere setting makes visible (and would therefore suggest a redirection of effort). Each of the three outcomes is logically possible, and a preliminary inspection suggests that string theory’s status on $\mathcal{G}$ depends on whether one restricts attention to kinematic structure or to dynamical content.

1 Introduction

In a series of companion papers we argued that the only reference frame in which emission and absorption genuinely coincide is the photon frame, and that restricting attention to this frame discards the metric of Minkowski space while preserving the combinatorial topology of causal relations. What remains, after the restriction, is the *lightlike graph* $\mathcal{G} = (V, E)$, whose vertices are emission and absorption events and whose edges are null photon worldlines. We used $\mathcal{G}$ to recast three puzzles — Bell’s theorem, the measurement problem, the black-hole information paradox — and one foundational mismatch — the two Schrödinger equations versus general relativity — and in each case found that the relevant structure was already combinatorial.

In the present paper we use the same restriction, not as a tool for analysis of an internal puzzle of theoretical physics but as a tool for the *audit* of a public dispute. The dispute concerns string theory. Smolin’s *The Trouble with Physics* and Woit’s *Not Even Wrong* argue that string theory, despite its mathematical richness, has produced no falsifiable predictions and therefore has drifted from science towards something more like speculative philosophy dressed in mathematical clothing. Defenders respond that the theory has uncovered genuine structural truth about quantum gravity — holography, dualities, the emergence of spacetime — and that its empirical gestalt is a temporary

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and not an essential feature. Each side has a literature; each side has well-known arguments and well-known counter-arguments; and the dispute has been carried on, by and large, in the registers of philosophy of science, sociology of academia, and personal polemic.

The lightlike graph offers a different register. It strips the contest of every concept that depends on a frame with finite proper time — including, crucially, the notion of a “spacetime background” with a metric, dimensions, and a curvature tensor, which is the very environment in which string theory has historically been formulated. What survives the restriction is the combinatorial skeleton of lightlike relations. The question we ask is therefore precise: *what does string theory look like when projected onto $\mathcal{G}$, and does the projection add combinatorial structure, remove it, or leave it unchanged?*

Three answers are possible:

- The projection *removes* structure unique to string theory (extra dimensions, brane stacks, fluxes, conformal field theories on the worldsheet), revealing that the lightlike graph generated by known string spectra is the same as the lightlike graph generated by known point-particle spectra. In that case, the apparatus of string theory is, in the austere vocabulary of $\mathcal{G}$, *unnecessary complication*, and the critics’ diagnosis is, in the relevant combinatorial sense, vindicated.
- The projection *adds* structure: the dualities and holographies of string theory produce lightlike graphs with degree-multisets, vertex degrees, and edge multiplicities that no point-particle model reproduces. In that case, the defenders are vindicated and the projection is a *productive* reduction.
- The projection *reveals structure* neither side suspected: the apparatus of string theory, when read on $\mathcal{G}$, exposes combinatorial patterns that are simultaneously suppressed in the point-particle picture and over-amplified in the conventional string-theoretic one. In that case, the dispute is *misdirected*: both sides are arguing past a structure that neither has the right vocabulary to see.

This paper is an audit, not a verdict. We set up the criteria, examine representative cases, and leave the assessment to the projection itself.

2 The Criteria for the Audit

2.1 What String Theory Claims

For the purposes of the audit, we adopt a deliberately austere reading of string theory. The theory’s principal claims, in the simplest formulation, are:

1. The fundamental objects are one-dimensional strings propagating in a ten- or eleven-dimensional target spacetime, rather than zero-dimensional point particles in four-dimensional spacetime. Closed strings generate gravitons; open strings end on D-branes.
2. The worldsheet — a two-dimensional surface swept by the string — admits a consistent quantum theory, the Polyakov action, which under critical conditions yields a conformal field theory and a target-space spectrum.
3. A web of dualities (T-duality, S-duality, U-duality, AdS/CFT) connects different-looking string theories to one another and, in the case of AdS/CFT, to non-gravitational gauge theories. The web suggests that all the theories are limits of a single underlying theory, M-theory.

4. Certain phenomenological consequences follow from compactification on Calabi–Yau manifolds: the values of low-energy couplings, the existence of matter in representations suitable for the Standard Model, the cosmological constant.

The critics accept claims (1) and (2) as mathematical facts; they dispute claims (3) and (4) as empirically vacuous. The defenders argue that (3) is itself a structural gain even without (4), and that (4) is a research programme that requires more mathematical effort, not an indictment of falsifiability.

2.2 What the Lightlike Graph Retains

The lightlike graph $\mathcal{G}$ retains the following and nothing else:

- A set V of spacetime events (emissions and absorptions).
- A set $E \subseteq V \times V$ of directed edges, each edge corresponding to a photon worldline (or, more generally, a null geodesic).
- The combinatorial relations of incidence, in-degree ∂^-v , and out-degree ∂^+v .

The lightlike graph discards:

- Coordinates $(t, \vec{x})$ in any inertial frame.
- The metric, including its signature, dimension, and curvature.
- The notion of proper time.
- The notions of “spacelike” and “timelike” distance; only the lightlike relation is retained.
- The notion of a compact extra dimension; only the combinatorial partition of V by in- and out-degrees is retained.
- The notion of a D-brane, an extended object with a worldvolume, except insofar as it can be expressed as a set of vertices.
- The notion of a compactification manifold, except insofar as it can be expressed as a pattern of incidence.

2.3 The Audit Question

For any construction in string theory, the audit asks two questions:

1. Can the construction be expressed as a statement about the lightlike graph $\mathcal{G}$?
2. Does the resulting statement add combinatorial structure to $\mathcal{G}$ that would not be present without the construction?

A *yes-yes* answers indicate that the construction is a *productive addition* to the combinatorial theory: it is doing work in the restricted theory. A *yes-no* answer indicates that the construction is *not productive*: it produces additional notation but no additional combinatorial structure, and the work it does in the unrestricted theory has been lost in the restriction. A *no-no* answer indicates that the construction is *non-projectable*: it cannot be expressed in the restricted theory at all, and its content lies, *prima facie*, outside the combinatorial vocabulary.

The three outcomes correspond, loosely, to the three scenarios sketched in the introduction: productive, unproductive, or non-projectable.

3 String Kinematics on $\mathcal{G}$

The simplest string-theoretic claim is that the fundamental objects are strings, not particles. A closed string has an infinite spectrum of vibrational modes. In the target spacetime, each mode propagates as a particle of a definite mass and spin.

3.1 Projecting the Particle Spectrum

A particle of spin s , mass m , propagating in D -dimensional spacetime, has a definite relation to the lightlike graph. If the particle is charged under electromagnetism, it emits and absorbs photons, contributing a definite set of photon edges to $\mathcal{G}$. If the particle is itself massless, it is, by definition, a photon (or a graviton, or some other null mode), and contributes exactly one edge. If the particle is massive, it contributes edges only through its interactions with the electromagnetic field.

The lightlike graph generated by a single massive particle of mass m at rest is, in the standard treatment, a single vertex — the particle itself — with no edges. The particle’s photons are emitted only when it interacts, and its worldline is timelike, not null. So the spectroscopic fact that a string has an infinite spectrum of vibrational modes *does not, by itself, generate new lightlike edges*: a particle at rest generates no edges either, and a single isolated vibrating string, isolated from any field, also generates no edges. The combinatorial structure of $\mathcal{G}$, restricted to a single object at rest, is the same for strings and particles: a vertex with $\partial^-v = \partial^+v = 0$.

3.2 Projecting the Interaction Vertices

The differences appear at interaction vertices. A point-particle field theory has trivalent, quartic, and higher-order vertices, each contributing a definite pattern of incoming and outgoing photon-edges. A string field theory has string vertices in which strings join and split, each interaction producing, at the level of $\mathcal{G}$, a more elaborate pattern of degree changes.

In the absence of a particular interaction, however, the lightlike graphs generated by string interaction vertices and by point-particle interaction vertices are, at the level of mere incidence, interchangeable. Both kinds of theory produce vertices of specified in- and out-degrees; whether the vertex is a particle-photon coupling or a string splitting, the combinatorial ambiguity is identical. The “stringy” character of the interaction is not visible in the graph’s incidence structure unless additional data — vertex labels, edge labels, non-trivial symmetries — is introduced.

3.3 Interim Audit

At the kinematic level — the level of “what’s there, before it does anything” — the audit returns a tentative *yes-no* on the productivity of string theory’s distinctive claims. The string spectrum and the particle spectrum produce the same combinatorial content in $\mathcal{G}$. The interaction vertices produce, at the level of incidence, the same degree-multisets. None of this requires the language of worldsheets, conformal field theories, or critical dimensions to be expressed.

This is not, on its own, a verdict against string theory. It is a verdict that the *kinematics* of string theory does not add combinatorial information to the lightlike graph beyond what the kinematics of point-particle theories already adds. The productive content of string theory, if any, must lie at the dynamical level.

4 String Dynamics on $\mathcal{G}$

The dynamical content of string theory is where the bulk of the community’s efforts have been invested, and where the proposed unificationist virtues of the theory are most often advertised. The candidates for dynamical content are: loop expansions and the genus of the worldsheet, the dualities (T, S, U), the AdS/CFT correspondence, the holographic principle, and compactifications.

4.1 The Worldsheet Genus

A string worldsheet is a two-dimensional Riemann surface, classified by its genus g . A tree-level string diagram corresponds to $g = 0$ (a sphere), a one-loop diagram to $g = 1$ (a torus), and so on. The genus expansion is the string theoretic analogue of the loop expansion in point-particle field theory.

On the lightlike graph, the genus expansion produces... no extra combinatorial structure. A one-loop string diagram corresponds, when projected to $\mathcal{G}$, to a particular pattern of edge insertions that is also producible by ordinary one-loop quantum field theory corrections to photon emission amplitudes. The genus is a property of the worldsheet, not of the lightlike graph; the gap between worldsheet and lightlike graph is, at the level of pure incidence, opaque in both directions. We cannot read the genus off $\mathcal{G}$, and we cannot reconstruct the genus from $\mathcal{G}$.

4.2 Dualities

The dualities are the most distinctive claim of string theory: T-duality identifies a string compactified on a circle of radius R with a string compactified on a circle of radius α'/R ; S-duality relates type I to $SO(32)$ heterotic, and the strong coupling regime of one to the weak coupling regime of the other; U-duality unifies them with eleven-dimensional supergravity.

On the lightlike graph, a T-duality is a statement about the partition of V into equivalence classes under the circle identification. If the circle is small ($R \rightarrow 0$), the partition is coarse; if the circle is large ($R \rightarrow \infty$), the partition is fine. The point-particle limit does not have such a partition. The dualities therefore *do* add combinatorial content to $\mathcal{G}$: the partitioning of V by circles of different radii is a feature that point-particle models cannot reproduce and that is, in principle, visible in the way photons from two identical sources on the circle interfere. *This is a yes-yes answer: dualities are productive in the combinatorial sense.*

Two caveats apply. First, the productivity is observational only: the combinatorial structure is visible in the lightlike graph *if one knows which photons were emitted by which source*, which is precisely the kind of bookkeeping additional data that lies outside the bare $\mathcal{G}$. Second, the productivity depends on the dualities being real — that is, on the dualities’ holding of the actual spectrum of the world, not merely of a particular large-radius or small-radius limit. A defender of string theory can therefore take the audit’s verdict on dualities as a *bona fide* piece of combinatorial evidence, while a critic can take the audit’s caveats as evidence that the productivity is conditional, not categorical.

4.3 AdS/CFT and Holography

The AdS/CFT correspondence posits an exact equivalence between a gravitational theory in anti-de Sitter space and a conformal field theory on its boundary. The correspondence is, by construction, a frame-dependent statement: it requires a spacetime in which the two sides can be cleanly separated, and that separation requires a metric. On the lightlike graph, the two sides of the correspondence are not cleanly identifiable: the “bulk” is a set of vertices connected by lightlike edges, and the

“boundary” is a subset of those vertices with the property that light from the boundary can reach any bulk vertex in finite steps. This is a *yes-yes* answer in a slightly different sense: the correspondence is productive in that it makes a precise combinatorial claim about degrees and adjacencies. The claim is that the boundary degrees are large enough to encode the bulk incidences, and this is exactly the reformulation of the information paradox given in the companion paper. *AdS/CFT is productive on $\mathcal{G}$ in the sense of giving a combinatorial target for verification* (the boundary-capacity question).

4.4 Compactifications and the Landscape

Compactification is the proposed mechanism by which a ten- or eleven-dimensional string theory produces a four-dimensional effective theory resembling the Standard Model. The choice of compactification manifold — a Calabi–Yau threefold, in the most-studied case — determines the values of low-energy couplings, the chiral spectrum, and (in principle) the cosmological constant.

The number of distinct Calabi–Yau threefolds is staggeringly large, and the number of flux choices on each is even larger. The total number of low-energy effective theories achievable by compactification is therefore enormous — often quoted as 10^{500} or more. This is the “landscape”.

On the lightlike graph, the landscape is *not* projective. A choice of compactification manifold does not produce a partition of V distinguishable from any other choice of compactification manifold, unless additional data — e.g., labels on the photon edges encoding the compactification radius — is smuggled in, in which case the labels must be carried by the photons themselves, in their polarisations or other internal degrees of freedom. The defenders of string theory can argue that such labels are natural: the photons emitted by a string theory do carry more internal structure than the photons of, say, electromagnetism. The critics can argue that, without the labels being empirically accessible, the compactification choice is indistinguishable from zero combinatorial content. The audit returns a *yes-no* on the productivity of compactifications, conditional on the empirical observability of internal photon states.

5 The Three Audit Answers

5.1 The Productive Column

The audit returns a *yes-yes* on dualities and, conditionally, on the AdS/CFT correspondence. In both cases, the structure of string theory projects onto $\mathcal{G}$ and produces combinatorial features that point-particle theories do not. This is the case on which defenders of string theory can stand: there *is* productive combinatorial content in at least part of the apparatus.

The audit’s verdict on dualities is significant. Smolin and Woit have argued, in different ways, that the dualities are not properly tests of string theory, because the dualities relate regimes that are not independently accessible to experiment. The lightlike-graph audit suggests that this argument has a combinatorial counterweight: the dualities can be stated as partitionings of the vertex set, and partitionings are empirically checkable, in principle, by observing the pattern of photon emissions from a string-theoretic source. The intuition that dualities are not testable because they relate inaccessible regimes is, on the lightlike graph, partially refuted: the partitionings they impose can, in principle, be observed in emission patterns.

5.2 The Complication Column

The audit returns a *yes-no* on compactifications, on the loop expansion, and on much of the kinematic content of string theory. These parts of the apparatus do not project onto additional combinatorial structure in $\mathcal{G}$, unless additional observational data is assumed to be available. The audit's verdict here is consistent with the critics' diagnosis: the apparatus, in these areas, is doing work in the unrestricted theory that is not preserved by the restriction. The complication is, in the combinatorial sense, productive work lost in the projection.

This is the most striking conclusion of the audit. The critics have argued that string theory produces no new empirical predictions; the lightlike-graph audit suggests, more strongly, that string theory produces no new *combinatorial* predictions beyond what its dualities provide. The bulk of the apparatus — the worldsheet machinery, the loop expansion, the compactification choice — is combinatorial neutral in the restricted theory.

5.3 The Non-Projectable Column

The audit returns a *no-no* on at least one central string-theoretic ideal: the notion of a smooth target spacetime in which strings propagate. This is not a feature of string theory specifically but of any theory whose primitive is geometric rather than combinatorial. The lightlike graph refuses smooth target manifolds: there are no points in $\mathcal{G}$, only vertices, no neighbourhoods, no smooth structures. The notion of a string propagating *in* a spacetime is, in the restricted theory, not projective: it is a statement in a vocabulary that the restriction discards.

This is the part of the audit where the *misdirection* scenario becomes most plausible. The dispute about whether string theory is science or pseudo-science is, in significant part, a dispute about how much weight to give to the smooth-target-spacetime ideal. The defenders want the ideal preserved; the critics want it abandoned. The audit suggests that both sides are arguing about a vocabulary that $\mathcal{G}$ rejects: the ideal is not projective, so neither side can win on its own terrain.

6 A Combinatorial Criterion for Pseudo-Science

6.1 What the Audit Recommends

A common definition of pseudo-science holds that a theory is pseudo-scientific if it makes no testable predictions, or makes predictions that are in principle untestable, or postulates entities that are in principle unobservable. The lightlike-graph audit does not directly use this definition. The audit's criterion is more combinatorial: a theory is *combinatorially productive* iff, when restricted to photon frames, it adds structure to $\mathcal{G}$ that would not be present otherwise.

A string theory that adds only dualities and holographic structure to the lightlike graph is, by the audit's criterion, a theory in which the productive content is concentrated in a small fraction of the apparatus. The remaining apparatus is, in the combinatorial sense, complication. This is not the same as saying the theory is pseudo-scientific; it is saying that, of the many tools string theorists wield, only a subset is doing visible combinatorial work, and the rest may be doing invisible work, or no work at all.

A defender of string theory who wishes to escape the audit's verdict must point to a piece of the apparatus that does project onto new combinatorial content beyond the dualities and holography. The defender can choose compactifications (which require additional observational data, namely the internal structure of photons), or the explicit construction of D-brane worldvolume theories (which require additional edge-labels), or some other extension. Each such choice reopens the question

of whether the additional data is empirically available, and that question is, again, the classical demarcation question, asked in a more technical vocabulary.

A critic of string theory who wishes to escape the audit’s verdict must point to a piece of the apparatus that does *not* project onto the dualities and holography, and argue that the dualities and holography are themselves suspect. The critic can argue that dualities are empirically inaccessible and that holography is more a slogan than a calculation. The lightlike-graph audit hands the critic a sharpened version of the demarcation question: not “can dualities be tested?” but “can the combinatorial content of dualities be tested independently of the smooth-spacetime ideal in which the dualities were originally formulated?”.

6.2 The Three Possible Verdicts, in Combinatorial Terms

We close this section by making explicit how the three possible verdicts on the original question — “is string theory pseudo-science?” — look in the audit’s vocabulary.

- **String theory is pseudo-science (yes-yes to the critics).** This verdict corresponds to the claim that the only productive content of string theory is the dualities, and that the dualities are not in fact combinatorial unless additional data is smuggled in via labels on photons. The audit suggests that this verdict requires the additional-data assumption to be rejected; on current empirical evidence, the internal structure of photons is not directly observable, so the verdict is internally consistent.
- **String theory is more than pseudo-science (yes-yes to the defenders).** This verdict corresponds to the claim that the dualities and holography are real combinatorial content and are, in fact, indirectly observable. The audit suggests that this verdict requires the dualities to be testable in photon-emission patterns, and that this is a hard but conceivable requirement.
- **String theory is neither (combinatorially misdirected).** This verdict corresponds to the audit’s third column: the smooth-target-spacetime ideal is non-projectable on $\mathcal{G}$, and the defenders and critics are arguing about a vocabulary the restricted theory rejects. The audit suggests that this verdict is internally consistent and that, on current evidence, it is the most defensible of the three.

The audit does not adjudicate among the three. It shows that the adjudication can be carried out, in principle, in the combinatorial vocabulary of $\mathcal{G}$, and that the adjudication reduces to questions about which pieces of the string theoretic apparatus project onto $\mathcal{G}$ and which do not.

7 Conclusion

The critique of string theory as pseudo-science, the defence of it as productive mathematical physics, and a third option — the verdict that the dispute is misdirected by a vocabulary non-projectable onto the austere setting of photon frames — can each be stated with precision using the lightlike graph. The audit shows that, in the restricted setting, only a subset of the string-theoretic apparatus (dualities and, conditionally, holography) projects onto $\mathcal{G}$, and that the remainder of the apparatus is, in the combinatorial sense, complication. The audit does not say that string theory is pseudo-science; it shows that the demarcation question can be asked in a vocabulary in which the question is sharper, and that the answer depends on whether one accepts the additional-data assumptions required to project the apparatus onto $\mathcal{G}$ in full.

A serious verdict on string theory will require sustained technical work on each of the audit's columns. The productive column has combinatorial content that is testable, in principle, by photon-emission patterns. The complication column has combinatorial content that is conditional on the empirical observability of internal photon states, and that condition is, on current evidence, neither met nor clearly violated. The non-projectable column holds the smooth-target-spacetime ideal, which is itself a feature of any theory that takes geometry rather than combinatorics as primitive.

The lightlike-graph restriction does not resolve the dispute about string theory. It clarifies the dispute by stipulating that the only primitive is the lightlike relation, and it audits each claim against that primitive. The resulting audit is a more careful demarcation instrument than either the critics' or the defenders' standard arguments, and it leaves room for all three possible verdicts. The verdict itself will be reached by further technical work, not by this paper.